

▷ VOCALIZATIONS

Small cats cannot roar as the big cats do. Instead, pumas snarl and hiss when annoyed and purr when content.

round head
with erect ears

large paws relative
to overall size



Puma

Puma concolor

North America's largest cat has more than 40 common names, including mountain lion and cougar. It is not classified as a big cat, but as the largest of the small cats. Once found across the US, it has now virtually disappeared from eastern and midwestern areas. Pumas farthest from the equator tend to be larger than those closer to it. Coat color also varies with geography; the most northern pumas are silver-gray, while those in southerly, humid climates tend to be reddish brown.

Previously elusive and solitary, pumas used to avoid contact with humans whenever possible, although they had been known to kill people when cornered. However, attacks recorded in North America have risen sharply since the 1990s, with hikers, mountain bikers, and skiers particularly at risk.

Flexible feline

Highly adaptable, pumas can live in habitats as diverse as deserts and tropical rainforests. This adaptability also extends to their diet. Although hoofed mammals are preferred—especially by mothers with cubs to feed—pumas hunt rabbits, feral pigs, insects, birds, mice, coyotes, and even other pumas. Although active during the day, they hunt mostly at dawn and dusk.

Female pumas can breed all year round. Males and females stay together for a few days when the female is in season. The male then leaves in search of other potential mates, playing no part in raising his offspring. In about three months, the female gives birth to two or three spotted cubs, which stay with her for up to 18 months. At 12–14 weeks, the cubs' spots begin to fade.

buff-colored,
thick fur



△ AGILE AND ATHLETIC

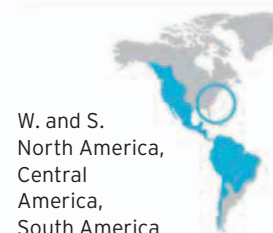
A puma's powerful hind legs allow it to bound up to 40 ft (12 m) when running, and leap up 18 ft (5.4 m) from the ground.

↔ 34–60 in (86–155 cm)

⚖ 75–160 lb (34–72 kg)

⊗ Common

🐾 Mammals



W. and S.
North America,
Central
America,
South America